

CORE FORMULA

D — Describe: name the observable behaviour. "In the last two meetings, the decision changed after we'd already agreed the scope." -> **E — Express:** name the effect, not the motive. "That makes it hard to plan the work and keep the team aligned." -> **S — Specify:** ask for the concrete change. "I need scope changes flagged before the meeting ends." -> **C — Consequence:** name your next step, not a punishment. "If that isn't possible, I'll pause implementation until we have it in writing." -> **Skeleton:** "When [behaviour] happens, it affects [impact]. I need [specific change]. If that can't happen, I'll [my own next step]."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

When [specific behaviour] happens, it affects [impact]. I need [specific change]. If that can't happen, I'll [clear next step].

BEST FOR

- Repeated minor boundary crossings
- Workplace feedback that needs a behaviour change
- Household and shared-living agreements
- Collaborative repair and role clarity
- Setting expectations and service interactions
- Client and scope conversations
- Any moment where a concrete behaviour needs to change

PHRASE BANK

Minimum viable move · Short skeletons and openers

- "When that keeps happening, it affects the work. I need one clear change. If it can't happen, I'll take the next step myself."
- "Can I name a pattern I'm seeing and make one request?"
- "Quick one: when the scope changes mid-task, I lose the day."
- "One ask — send changes in writing, and I'll re-quote before I continue."
- "I need it by Thursday; after that it moves to the next cycle."
- "Small thing, but it keeps happening. Can we sort it?"
- "Two-line version: this happens, I need that, or I'll do this."

Warm and collaborative · Keeps the relationship in frame

- "I'm raising this because I want us to work well together."
- "I want to keep helping, and I also need the scope to stay stable."
- "None of this is about blame — I just want us on the same page."
- "I value your input; I'm asking about timing, not shutting it down."
- "I'd rather say this now than let it quietly build up."
- "I want your pushback — it makes the plan better."
- "This matters to me because the working relationship matters."

Work and meetings · Feedback, teams, clients, email

- "When the draft comes in after the review window, I can't give it proper attention. I need it by Tuesday noon. If it's later, it moves to the next review cycle."
- "When side conversations happen while someone is presenting, it splits attention. Let's hold questions until the end; put anything urgent in the chat."
- "When I get several urgent pings without context, I lose time guessing priority. Please include the deadline and the

decision needed. If I don't have that, I'll treat it as normal priority."

- "When requirements change after sign-off, the timeline and cost change too. Please send changes in writing; if the scope changes, I'll send an updated estimate before continuing."
- "When approval comes after the deadline, I can't protect quality. I need it by Thursday; if it's later, launch moves to the next cycle."
- "In the last two meetings the decision changed after we'd agreed the scope. That makes it hard to plan. I need scope changes flagged before we close."

Clear ask and boundary · The Specify and Consequence steps

- "Please let me finish the timeline before challenging it."
- "I need the scope settled before I begin."
- "Please send changes in writing."
- "I can do this if the scope stays fixed. If it changes again today, I'll pause and replan."
- "Please clear your dishes before bed; if they're still there in the morning, I'll leave them on your side rather than doing them."
- "Let me know as soon as you're unsure about plans. If it's last-minute again, I'll wait for you to suggest the next one."
- "If the concern is urgent, say 'I need to interrupt for a risk,' and I'll pause."

Soften and recover · When the tone lands hard

- "That came out sharper than I intended — I'm not threatening you, I'm being clear about what I can and can't do."
- "I made that sound more like a threat than a boundary. Let me restate it."
- "I'm not trying to diagnose your intention; I'm describing the behaviour I experienced."
- "The part I need to be clear about is my next step, not controlling yours."
- "Let me separate the facts from my reaction."
- "I skipped listening. Before I restate the request — what am I missing?"
- "That was too much at once. One-line version: when this happens, I need that, or I'll do this."

Pressure and pushback · Under resistance or when it lands heavily

- "You can absolutely challenge it — I'm asking for sequencing, not silence. Finish first, challenge second."
- "I can hear the consequence landed heavily; the request still matters, and I want to make it fair."
- "I'm not asking you to agree, only to hear what I need."
- "If we can't settle this here, I'll take it to the next step rather than keep going in circles."
- "Let's slow down. Here's the behaviour I mean, without the label."
- "You can decide how you want to handle it; I'm being clear about what I'll do next."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "You keep ignoring what I ask for, so don't be surprised if I stop helping." This attacks motive and turns the consequence into punishment.

Better: "When the request changes after I've started, I lose time. I need the scope settled before I begin. If it changes, I'll need to re-estimate." Clearer and far less blaming.

Best: "I want to keep helping, and I also need the scope stable. When it changes after I start, I lose time and quality drops. Please confirm the scope before I begin. If it changes, I'll pause and send a new estimate before continuing." Warmth, specificity, request and boundary held together.

2. Weak: Overloading the other person with a long case file of everything they've ever done.

Better: Naming one concrete pattern.

Best: Naming one pattern, one impact, one request and one respectful next step — then pausing for their response.

DECISION TREE

If The issue isn't observable yet

Don't use DESC. Ask a clarifying question or reflect first.

"Can I check what actually happened before I react?"

If It's observable but low-stakes and one-off

Use a clean request instead of the full frame.

"Could you get that to me by Tuesday?"

If It's observable and repeated

Use DESC: describe, express, specify, then set the boundary.

"When this keeps happening, it affects the work. I need one clear change. If not, I'll..."

If They're distressed or escalated

Validate or pause first; use a shorter DESC only if it's still needed.

"Let's take a breath — I do want to sort this out with you."

If The consequence would be punitive or unsafe

Don't use it. Name your own next action, seek support, or move to a formal process.

"I'll take this through the proper process rather than handle it here."

If They understand and agree

Summarise the next step and stop talking.

"Great — so you'll flag scope before we close, and we're set."

SCENARIOS

Workplace delay

Name the deadline impact and make the fallback a process, not a punishment. — "When approval comes after the deadline, I can't protect quality. I need it by Thursday; if it's later, launch moves to the next cycle."

Household boundary

State the agreement, the effect, and your own next action. — "When dishes are left overnight after we agreed to clear them, I start the day frustrated. Please clear yours before bed; if they're still there, I'll move them to your side rather than doing them."

Friendship

Describe the pattern and set a boundary about your own effort, not a threat. — "When plans are cancelled once I'm already on the way, I feel disrespected. Please tell me as soon as you're unsure; if it's last-minute again, I'll wait for you to suggest the next plan."

Client scope creep

Turn the consequence into a transparent process. — "When new requirements are added after sign-off, the estimate changes. Please send changes in writing; if scope changes, I'll pause and quote the revision before continuing."

Digital overload

Ask for the context you need and set a default if it's missing. — "When I get multiple urgent messages without context, I can't triage. Please include the deadline and decision needed; if not, I'll respond in the normal queue."

Team disagreement

Sequence the input and leave a clear channel for genuine risk. — "When objections come before the proposal is complete, the group misses the full logic. Please hold objections until the summary slide; if there's a critical risk, name it as a risk and I'll pause."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- There is immediate danger, harassment or a crisis — use formal support, documentation or safety planning
- A power imbalance means a private, direct conversation could increase harm
- You cannot yet name the behaviour specifically
- The other person is too distressed, ashamed or escalated to take in structure
- Your real aim is to win, shame, punish or test loyalty
- You are too escalated to stay respectful
- The ask is small and one-off — a clean request is enough

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Draft the four lines

Pick one mild real situation. Write a single sentence for each DESC step: Describe, Express, Specify, Consequence.

Day 2 — Strip the judgement

Underline every judgement or motive word in your draft and swap it for an observable behaviour anyone could have seen.

Day 3 — Impact without blame

Rewrite the Express line so it names the effect on you or the work without making them responsible for your feelings.

Day 4 — Make it observable

Sharpen the Specify line until a stranger could tell whether or not it actually happened.

Day 5 — Boundary, not punishment

Rewrite the Consequence as your own next action — what you'll do — rather than a threat about what they'll suffer.

Day 6 — Cut it by a third

Say the full version aloud, then trim roughly a third of the words so it sounds like a conversation, not a statement.

Day 7 — Add the calibration line

End with one line that hands back choice — "How does that land?" or "What am I missing?" — and use the whole thing once in a real conversation.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I describe behaviour rather than motive or character?
- Did I express impact without making the other person responsible for my emotional regulation?
- Was my request specific, observable and proportionate?
- Was the consequence a respectful next step rather than a threat?
- Did I leave room for correction, context or negotiation?
- Did I avoid using the frame to pressure, corner, sell, punish or dominate — and did I know when to stop, document or escalate instead?